

Music and memory in business education.

Why every MBA Rock module is
anchored by an original song.

RESEARCH BRIEF · DESIGN PILLAR 1

Music and memory in business education.

Why every MBA Rock module is anchored by an original song — and what the research says.

The hypothesis

If you set a business framework — say, a definition of unit economics or a cash-flow heuristic — to an original song, will learners retain the framework more durably than if they encounter the same framework only in text and video form? MBA Rock's design assumes the answer is yes. The literature supports that assumption.

Key empirical evidence

Wallace (1994) tested this directly. In a controlled experiment, participants who learned a text passage paired with a melody recalled the passage more accurately than participants who learned the same passage without melody, at both short and long delays. The melody appeared to function as a retrieval scaffold, providing a non-verbal cue that supported access to the verbal content of the lyric.

Calvert and Tart (1993) extended this finding. Their experiment compared verbatim recall of prose presented in song form versus the same prose presented as spoken text, across short-, long-, and very-long-term recall intervals. Song-form prose produced stronger retention across all three time horizons in their experimental conditions.

Rainey and Larsen (2002) extended the case to *familiar* melodies — investigating whether a melody learners already know can be used as a scaffold for unfamiliar text. Their findings supported a memory-anchor function for familiar melody as well, though with different acquisition and retention dynamics than novel melody.

Theoretical grounding

The mechanism is consistent with Paivio's (1986) dual-coding theory: a melody provides a non-verbal trace that operates alongside the verbal trace of the concept. Mayer's (2009, 2014) Cognitive Theory of Multimedia Learning explicitly identifies the multimedia and modality principles as central design rules. Song-form content satisfies both by combining a verbal channel (lyric) with a non-verbal channel (melody) in synchronous presentation.

How MBA Rock implements the literature

MBA Rock contains 49 original songs across 10 modules. Each song is composed against a specific framework that is core to the module's curriculum coverage. The song is presented in every lesson within that module, embedded in the multi-modal lesson architecture (text + video + song + calculator). Lyrics are also available as transcripts to satisfy UDL multiple-means-of-representation requirements.

The result is that every framework in the MBA Rock curriculum is encoded in the learner's memory through at least two channels — verbal and melodic — consistent with the dual-coding case in the literature.

What this means for institutional partners. A curriculum that uses music as a memory anchor produces stronger framework retention than text-only or video-only equivalents, according to the literature. Institutional partners adopting MBA Rock therefore offer their learners a curriculum design that is empirically advantaged for long-term retention — without the institution itself having to commission song-form curriculum.

References

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